

« Proud of winning Paralympic silver, but the true reward lies in never giving up, showing up each day, and living life as it's meant to be lived »

PRANAV SOORMA

People are always surprised when I tell them about my practice schedule. My day begins when most people are asleep. I wake up at 1 a.m. so I can reach the training ground by 3, where my coach, Naval Singh sir, is waiting.

I train at that time as a consequence of my spinal injury — my body doesn't sweat naturally. In summer, once the sun rises after 6 or 7, exercising and doing explosive movements becomes nearly impossible for me. So, I work from 3 a.m. to around 9 a.m., winding down just as other athletes are starting their sessions.

I've followed this routine since 2022, when I began training with Naval sir. It might sound strange, but it works. It brought me medals at the 2022 Asian Para Games and a silver at the Paris Paralympics, and I'm hoping it will help me again at the upcoming World Championships in New Delhi.

The challenge this time is the

change in equipment. In club throw, our club weighs around 400 grams, but its weight distribution has now been altered. That makes it harder to throw as far, much like when the javelin's weight was changed and the world record dropped from over 100m to around 97m. I still think a winning throw in New Delhi will be close to 35m, and I believe I can reach that mark.

When I think about results, I won't lie — I want a gold medal. According to Naval sir, that's the only medal that counts. I feel I could have won

gold at the Paris Paralympics too, but fate had other plans. At the Indian selection trials, I threw 37.23m. But three days before my event in Paris, I was struck by a severe fever and infection. I couldn't leave my bed for two days before competing.

Still, Naval sir kept me going. He told me, half-jokingly, that he wouldn't let me back into India without a medal. By God's blessing, I managed to summon enough strength to throw for a silver despite my condition.

This time, though, I want to



Destiny, too, plays its part. My surname, Soorma, means the ultimate fighter in Punjabi. I believe it's in my blood to fight till the end. That's why I brand my name everywhere — on my wheelchair, my T-shirt, even my caps. I want people to see it. And now, they do.